The USSR

During the latter part of 1941, Germany made its boldest move to date when it tried to invade the USSR. Initially, the German forces made great strides into the Soviet Union. They marched all the way to the heart of the country but realized their mistake too late. The country was too vast and despite Russian forces being weak enough, the bitter cold winters proved too much for the German army. After losses at Kursk and Stalingrad in 1943, the Germans had no choice but to fall back. In 1944, the German forces withdrew from Russia entirely and the Soviet army chased them back into Germany the following year.

Despite the Nazi-Soviet Pact of August 1939, Hitler's goal had always been to attack the Soviet Union. Hitler's main ideology included two key objectives: the killing of Jews and lebensraum. He massacred the Jews because he believed them to be the reason for Germany's demise in World War I. Lebensraum, or living space, involved obtaining extra dominion in the east and the oppression of the Slavic race. This was intended to be a war of destruction because Russia had mostly ignored the Geneva Convention. In Hitler's view, this required the implementation of 'executive measures' in captured domains.

Even with the vastness of the Russian border, Hitler had expected a speedy triumph. This is the reason why he did not bother to equip his soldiers with heavy supplies and winter uniforms. 'You only have to kick in the door,' said Hitler without hesitation, 'and the whole rotten structure will come slamming down.' Two tons of Iron Crosses were being held in Germany as rewards for those who were to carry out the destruction of Moscow.

The Soviets' difficult battle against the Finns proved to Hitler that the Soviets were not that strong at all. He underestimated the Soviets because of their past military campaigns. Furthermore, he trusted the Russian population to welcome his troops and in many places, this is exactly what happened. However, in most of Russia, the invasion by the Nazis was not seen in a positive light at all. The Germans' ruthless strategies had effectively alienated the people.